

Chapter 26

After Yin Lingzhu finished filming the program, it was already a month later.

Although the three of them didn't make it to the final, their stage performances were very good, so the production team was generous with giving them screen time.

Yin Lingzhu turned on the hotel television, and what was broadcasting on screen was this very program.

The stage lights flickered, and Yin Lingzhu's trio danced on stage—an explosive dance that had the audience below screaming wildly.

Yin Lingzhu watched the screen, holding a water cup in her hand, sitting on the bed.

When the program ended, Yin Lingzhu's cup was also empty.

She remembered her first time on stage, a small concert with less than fifty audience members below. Now, she had appeared on such a popular program stage.

Yin Lingzhu believed that if their team continued working hard, they would eventually be able to stand at the peak one day.

She looked around her hotel room. After moving out of the dormitory, this had become her place of residence.

If there were no mishaps in the future, she might continue living here.

She had originally planned to buy herself a house after paying back Yan Si's money.

But looking at house prices on her phone, Yin Lingzhu thought she might as well continue living in the hotel.

Just as Yin Lingzhu was feeling nostalgic, Yang Daiyi¹ suddenly called.

"Little Yin, come to the company." Yang Daiyi's voice sounded a bit off, but Yin Lingzhu didn't notice.

She hummed in acknowledgment, and after agreeing with Yang Daiyi, took a taxi to the company.

Yin Lingzhu pushed open the office door. Not only was Yang Daiyi inside, but Wan Miaoyin and Kong Murui were also there.

Yin Lingzhu was about to go forward and greet them, but she also sensed the heavy atmosphere in the air.

"What's wrong?" Yin Lingzhu entered and said with forced lightness.

"Your three-person team will probably have to disband." Yang Daiyi's voice was heavy as he took out a contract from the drawer.

"Although your contracts haven't expired yet, the company has already made a decision."

Yang Daiyi paused, "The company will pay the penalty fees."

Hearing Yang Daiyi's words, Yin Lingzhu's heart sank.

"Why?" Yin Lingzhu asked dryly.

Yang Daiyi didn't speak, silently placing the contract in front of the three people.

Kong Murui was quite straightforward about signing, and Wan Miaoyin also hesitated briefly before writing her name.

Yin Lingzhu held the pen, the tip hovering above the signature line for a long time without falling.

"I don't want to sign." She looked at the contract, where the two words 'termination' stung her eyes.

"Let me tell you the truth—the company wants to promote others, and you're in the way."

Hearing this explanation, anger and helplessness rose in Yin Lingzhu's heart.

She still signed her name, with such force that it went through the entire paper.

Seeing that Yin Lingzhu had also signed, Yang Daiyi sighed as he collected her contract.

After Yang Daiyi left with the contracts, the three people remained in the room.

"See you later." Kong Murui spoke first, smiled at the two of them, turned around and waved, leaving gracefully.

Yin Lingzhu watched her manner and imitated it, "See you in the rivers and lakes²."

After Kong Murui left, Yin Lingzhu turned to look at Wan Miaoyin.

Wan Miaoyin was also looking at her.

"Do you know why I came here?" Wan Miaoyin said softly.

Perhaps her voice was too quiet, or perhaps it was the current atmosphere, but Yin Lingzhu heard several notes of regret in it.

"Didn't you like singing since university? You said your goal was to become an international singer." Yin Lingzhu recalled.

Golden sunlight lay between them, like chains, like a partition.

But Wan Miaoyin shook her head slightly, the light reflecting in her eyes, "No."

"I don't like singing. Do you remember the first time you met me?"

"That time in the KTV, you said I sang well."

Wan Miaoyin looked at her, her pale hand reaching up, wanting to caress Yin Lingzhu's cheek. When it was about to make contact, as if burned, she withdrew her hand.

"I lied to you. I came here for you." Wan Miaoyin's voice was lonely, regretful.

Yin Lingzhu looked at her, "I'm sorry."

During that ambiguous period, the one who got hurt most was the one who gave her true heart.

"You have nothing to be sorry for." Wan Miaoyin traced Yin Lingzhu's appearance with her eyes, as if wanting to carve her into her heart.

"I often wonder, if I had stayed back then, taking care of you in the hospital room."

"Would the person who married you have been me?"

Yin Lingzhu remained silent. She knew the answer to this question, and Wan Miaoyin knew it too.

Wan Miaoyin smiled, "I wish you a smooth career and smooth sailing."

When she stood up to leave, sunlight fell on her for a moment, but only for a moment.

The moment Wan Miaoyin opened the door, Yan Si, who had been eavesdropping, fell into the room due to inertia.

Seeing Yan Si, Wan Miaoyin smiled politely at her.

Yan Si straightened her clothes and smiled back at her.

In the room, Yin Lingzhu sat on the sofa, watching Yan Si's movements.

"I heard everything," Yan Si said in a low voice as she entered the office and closed the door.

"Yan Si, is it that you heard everything, or is this something you did?"

Yin Lingzhu looked at her with cold eyes.

Yan Si stood at the door, looking quite at a loss.

"I didn't, it wasn't me." She defended herself in a low voice.

"I swear, I didn't know anything about this." Yan Si looked pitiful, almost raising her four fingers.

Yin Lingzhu watched her performance, not believing her at all.

Yan Si noticed Yin Lingzhu's gaze, "I really didn't know. If I knew, I wouldn't have been eavesdropping at the door."

Hearing her mention 'eavesdropping,' Yin Lingzhu's resolve wavered slightly.

Really didn't know?

But in her mind, she recalled how Yan Si had deceived her repeatedly.

Even what happened a month ago—Yin Lingzhu believed there was nothing Yan Si couldn't do.

Her momentarily wavering heart immediately became firm again.

"Your mouth is on your body, you can say whatever you want." Yin Lingzhu deliberately used words to provoke her.

Yan Si noticed her change, "Wait for me a moment, I'll go investigate who it was."

Yan Si was about to leave after saying this to settle accounts with someone, but when her hand touched the door handle, she suddenly turned to ask Yin Lingzhu.

"Is that okay?"

Yin Lingzhu was confused by her question. What was okay?

"Can you wait for me a moment?"

Yin Lingzhu nodded.

She wanted to see what person Yan Si would produce for her.

The moment she closed the door from outside, Yan Si sent a message to her assistant, calling for a meeting.

The assistant was very efficient. By the time Yan Si reached the conference room, the personnel were already assembled.

"Find the people under you who are forming girl groups." Yan Si's eagle-like eyes stared straight at them, her voice carrying anger.

Half an hour later, Yin Lingzhu looked at the two people in front of her, feeling very helpless.

"Yan Si, you don't need to do this."

Had Yan Si just randomly pulled in some scapegoats?

"No, it really wasn't me." Yan Si looked at Yin Lingzhu pitifully, her eyes moist, like a little dog.

Yin Lingzhu was amused by her own imagination, followed by indescribable anger and disgust.

Yin Lingzhu pushed Yan Si away. The moment she opened the door to leave, seeing the gossipers outside, she quietly closed the door again.

She really had been driven mad by Yan Si.

"Yan Si, I know it wasn't you who did it."

If this matter had been done by Yan Si, then Yan Si should have been careful and cautious, not making such a big spectacle.

Thinking of the group of people just now, their gossipy hearts were written all over their faces.

After all, a company executive and a company president coming to an eighteenth-tier small idol—how could that not make people think?

"I, I didn't expect this either." Yan Si also saw those people outside when Yin Lingzhu opened the door just now.

Yan Si quickly sent another message to her assistant, telling her to find some work for everyone.

"I was too anxious." After catching the person who was taking the blame for her, Yan Si had rushed over in a hurry, not paying attention to the people around her at all.

However, her credibility with Yin Lingzhu had already dropped to the lowest point.

"Yan Si, even if this matter wasn't your doing, our team has already disbanded." Yin Lingzhu's voice was cold, carrying mockery.

Yan Si glared at the executive in front of her.

The executive, sensing her gaze, pressed himself further into the corner, trying to reduce his presence.

"If you want, you can sign another contract, never to disband."

When Yan Si said this, her heart was filled with bitterness. She had heard what Wan Miaoyin said to Yin Lingzhu.

Yin Lingzhu shook her head, "No need, it's too late to talk about this now."

"It's not too late, it's not too late." Yan Si quickly took out her phone, "I'll notify your agent now that the contract can be void."

Yan Si's anxious appearance was something Yin Lingzhu had never seen before.

Before signing the divorce agreement, Yan Si had always been cold toward her, her face showing no smile at all.

As if she were a programmed robot, Yin Lingzhu couldn't feel any emotion from her.

The current Yan Si—Yin Lingzhu had seen many sides of her, mostly in disheveled states, but they had more vitality than before.

"No need, perhaps this is fate." Yin Lingzhu sighed and pressed down Yan Si's phone.

"Maybe I shouldn't be in this industry." Yin Lingzhu smiled bitterly.

Just before coming here, the TV was still showing their stage performance, and she had been fantasizing about her future life.

Yan Si suddenly panicked, "You can make him pay any price you want."

She pointed at the executive, looking at Yin Lingzhu with pleading eyes.

"Him? He has nothing to do with me. Yan Si, manage your subordinates properly." After Yin Lingzhu finished speaking, she opened the door again.

The gossipers outside were now working very hard.

Yin Lingzhu walked outside the company and let out a long breath.

Footnotes:

¹ Yang Daiyi (楊代亦): Yin Lingzhu's manager/agent

² "See you in the rivers and lakes" (江湖見): A traditional Chinese farewell phrase meaning "until we meet again in the world" - commonly used when parting ways in uncertain circumstances, with connotations of adventure and wandering